

Regenerative Community Operating System (RCOS)

Core Specification

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- Version: RCOS-Core v0.1
- Audience: Community founders, practitioners, auditors, implementers
- Normative keywords: **MUST** , **MUST NOT** , **SHOULD** , **MAY** (RFC-style)

Online: <https://rcos.ecohubs.community/standard/core/0.1>

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Introduction

0.1 Purpose of RCOS

Defines a standardized, modular operating system for small, intentional communities focused on resilience, fairness, and regeneration.

0.2 Scope of the Core

This specification defines the **mandatory core layers** required for RCOS compliance. Domain-specific practices are excluded and addressed via optional modules.

0.3 Design Principles

- Constraint-based, not value-based
- Pre-commitment over improvisation
- Modular by default
- Human-scale
- Failure-tolerant

0.4 Definitions & Terminology

- Community
- Member
- Role
- Domain
- Commons
- Invariant

- Decision Type
- Compliance

RCOS Compliance Model

1.1 Compliance Levels

- RCOS-Core compliant
- RCOS-Core + modules (non-normative)

1.2 Explicitness Requirement

Any mechanism affecting power, resources, obligations, or exit **MUST** be explicit, documented, and reviewable.

1.3 Meta-Invariant

If it is not written and adopted, it does not exist.

Layer 0 – Identity & Scope

Layer 0 defines the constitutional identity of the community. It establishes what the community *is*, what it *is not*, and the non-negotiable constraints under which all other layers operate. No rule, decision, or practice in higher layers may contradict Layer 0.

2.1 Purpose Definition

- 2.1.1 A community **MUST** define exactly one primary purpose.
- 2.1.2 The primary purpose **MUST** describe the enduring reason for the community's existence and **MUST NOT** be a short-term goal, project, or strategy.
- 2.1.3 The primary purpose **MUST** be stable across time and **MUST** only be changed through a constitutional decision as defined in [Layer 2](#) and executed via the change process defined in [Layer 6](#).
- 2.1.4 Secondary purposes **MAY** be defined, but **MUST NOT** conflict with or override the primary purpose.
- 2.1.5 No action, decision, or allocation of resources **MAY** materially contradict the stated primary purpose.

2.2 Scope Declaration

- 2.2.1 The community **MUST** explicitly declare the scope of what it governs.
- 2.2.2 The scope declaration **MUST** include, at minimum:
 - Assets governed by the community
 - Domains of decision-making authority
 - Activities and responsibilities under collective control
- 2.2.3 The scope declaration **MUST** explicitly list what is out of scope.

- 2.2.4 Anything not explicitly declared as in scope **MUST** be treated as out of scope.
- 2.2.5 The community **MUST NOT** exercise authority over persons, assets, or domains that are declared out of scope.

2.3 Invariants

- 2.3.1 Invariants are constraints that define what **MUST NOT** be violated while they are in force.
- 2.3.2 Invariants **MUST** be explicitly listed and documented.
- 2.3.3 Invariants **MUST** apply across all layers of RCOS.
- 2.3.4 No decision, role, process, or emergency measure **MAY** override an invariant.
- 2.3.5 If a conflict arises between an invariant and any other rule, the invariant **MUST** prevail.
- 2.3.6 Invariants **MAY** only be changed or removed through a constitutional change process as defined in [Layer 2](#) and [Layer 6](#).

2.4 Identity Constraints

- 2.4.1 The community **MUST** declare any identity-level constraints that materially affect participation, behavior, or governance.
- 2.4.2 Identity constraints **MAY** include, but are not limited to:
- Ethical or behavioral boundaries
 - Participation prerequisites
 - Non-negotiable cultural or ecological constraints
- 2.4.3 Identity constraints **MUST** be testable and enforceable through defined processes.
- 2.4.4 Identity constraints **MUST NOT** be enforced implicitly or informally.

2.5 Artifacts

2.5.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 0 compliance:

- Purpose Charter
- Scope Declaration
- Invariants Register
- Identity Constraints Register

2.5.2 Layer 0 artifacts **MUST** be:

- Publicly accessible to all members
- Versioned
- Adopted through a formal ratification process

2.5.3 If Layer 0 artifacts are missing, ambiguous, or internally contradictory, the community **MUST** be considered non-compliant with RCOS-Core.

Layer 1 – Membership System

Layer 1 defines how individuals enter, participate in, and exit the community. It establishes the explicit relationship between the individual and the collective, including rights, obligations, and due process. No person may be treated as a member without passing through the mechanisms defined in this layer.

3.1 Membership States

- 3.1.1 The community **MUST** define explicit membership states.
- 3.1.2 At minimum, the following membership states **MUST** exist:
 - Applicant
 - Trial / Probationary Member
 - Full Member
 - Exited Member
- 3.1.3 Each membership state **MUST** have clearly defined rights, obligations, and limitations.
- 3.1.4 No individual **MAY** hold multiple membership states simultaneously.
- 3.1.5 No rights or obligations **MAY** be assumed outside of the individual's current membership state.

3.2 Entry and Onboarding

- 3.2.1 Entry into the community **MUST** follow an explicit onboarding process.
- 3.2.2 The onboarding process **MUST** include:
 - Review of all RCOS-Core artifacts
 - Explicit consent to Layer 0 and Layer 1 rules
 - Declaration of initial membership state
- 3.2.3 Admission criteria **MUST** be explicit and documented.
- 3.2.4 Informal, implicit, or retroactive membership **MUST NOT** be permitted.

3.3 Trial and Evaluation

- 3.3.1 The community **MUST** define a probationary period for new members.
- 3.3.2 The probationary period **MUST** have:
 - A defined duration
 - Explicit evaluation criteria
 - A clear transition decision process
- 3.3.3 During probation, rights **MAY** be limited but obligations **MUST** be explicit.
- 3.3.4 Failure to transition from probation **MUST** trigger a defined exit or extension process.

3.4 Rights and Obligations

- 3.4.1 The community **MUST** explicitly define member rights.
- 3.4.2 The community **MUST** explicitly define member obligations.
- 3.4.3 Rights and obligations **MUST** be symmetrical and proportionate to membership state.
- 3.4.4 No obligation **MAY** be enforced without a corresponding, documented right.
- 3.4.5 Obligations **MUST NOT** be open-ended or undefined.

3.5 Participation and Contribution

- 3.5.1 Participation expectations **MUST** be explicitly defined.
- 3.5.2 Acceptable forms of contribution **MUST** be listed.
- 3.5.3 Substitution of participation (e.g., outsourcing labor) **MUST** be explicitly governed.
- 3.5.4 Persistent non-participation **MUST** trigger an accountability process as defined in Layer 4.

3.6 Exit and Separation

- 3.6.1 Voluntary exit **MUST** be possible at all times.
- 3.6.2 Exit procedures **MUST** be explicit, documented, and non-punitive.
- 3.6.3 Forced exit **MUST** follow due process and be handled through Layer 4 mechanisms.
- 3.6.4 Exit **MUST NOT** result in loss of rights beyond those explicitly tied to membership.
- 3.6.5 Asset, role, and responsibility separation **MUST** be defined prior to exit.

3.7 Suspension and Temporary Status

- 3.7.1 The community **MAY** define temporary suspension states.
- 3.7.2 Suspension conditions **MUST** be explicit, time-bounded, and reviewable.
- 3.7.3 Suspension **MUST NOT** be used as an indefinite or punitive substitute for exit.

3.8 Artifacts

- 3.8.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 1 compliance:
 - Membership Agreement
 - Onboarding Protocol
 - Exit & Separation Protocol
 - Membership State Registry
- 3.8.2 Layer 1 artifacts **MUST** be:
 - Explicit and unambiguous
 - Versioned
 - Accessible to all members
- 3.8.3 Absence, ambiguity, or systematic violation of Layer 1 artifacts **MUST** result in loss of RCOS-Core compliance.

Layer 2 — Governance & Decision Logic

Layer 2 defines how collective decisions are made, who is authorized to make them, and how authority is constrained. Governance under RCOS is designed to make power explicit, bounded, reviewable, and reversible.

4.1 Decision Types

- 4.1.1 All collective decisions **MUST** be classified into exactly one of the following decision types:
- Operational Decisions
 - Strategic Decisions
 - Constitutional Decisions
- 4.1.2 Operational Decisions concern day-to-day functioning and execution within existing rules.
- 4.1.3 Strategic Decisions concern long-term direction, allocation of significant resources, or creation/removal of major structures.
- 4.1.4 Constitutional Decisions concern changes to Layer 0 invariants, purpose, scope, or the governance system itself.
- 4.1.5 If a decision cannot be clearly classified, it **MUST** default to the higher-impact decision type.

4.2 Decision Mechanisms

- 4.2.1 Each decision type **MUST** have an explicitly defined decision-making mechanism.

- 4.2.2 Decision mechanisms **MAY** include, but are not limited to:
- Consent-based decision-making
 - Majority vote
 - Supermajority vote
 - Delegated authority
 - Randomized or rotational assignment
- 4.2.3 Decision mechanisms **MUST** specify:
- Eligible participants
 - Decision thresholds
 - Blocking or veto conditions, if any
 - Time constraints
- 4.2.4 No informal or ad hoc decision mechanism **MAY** be used for collective decisions.

4.3 Authority Boundaries

- 4.3.1 All authority **MUST** be assigned to explicitly defined roles, circles, or bodies.
- 4.3.2 Authority assignments **MUST** include:
- Scope of authority
 - Limits of authority
 - Duration or term, if applicable
- 4.3.3 No individual or body **MAY** exercise authority outside its explicitly assigned scope.
- 4.3.4 Authority **MUST NOT** be derived from charisma, seniority, ownership, or informal influence.
- 4.3.5 Temporary or emergency authority **MUST** be explicitly defined, time-bounded, and subject to review.

4.4 Decision Matrix

- 4.4.1 The community **MUST** maintain a Decision Matrix as a core governance artifact.
- 4.4.2 The Decision Matrix **MUST** map, at minimum:
 - Decision type
 - Decision domain
 - Authorized role or body
 - Decision mechanism
 - Approval threshold
 - Escalation path
- 4.4.3 The Decision Matrix **MUST** be publicly accessible to all members.
- 4.4.4 Decisions made outside the Decision Matrix **MUST** be considered invalid.

4.5 Governance Protocol

- 4.5.1 The community **MUST** define a Governance Protocol describing the full lifecycle of a decision.
- 4.5.2 The Governance Protocol **MUST** include:
 - Proposal submission requirements
 - Review and deliberation process
 - Decision execution
 - Documentation and publication
 - Appeal and review mechanisms
- 4.5.3 The Governance Protocol **MUST** define how conflicts between decisions are resolved.
- 4.5.4 All governance actions **MUST** be documented according to Layer 5 documentation rules.

4.6 Safeguards and Failure Modes

- 4.6.1 The governance system **MUST** include safeguards against:
- Concentration of decision power
 - Informal vetoes
 - Decision capture by subgroups
 - Founder or role entrenchment
- 4.6.2 Governance mechanisms **MUST** allow for challenge and review without retaliation.
- 4.6.3 Persistent governance failures **MUST** trigger a formal review or constitutional process.

4.7 Artifacts

- 4.7.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 2 compliance:
- Decision Matrix
 - Governance Protocol
 - Authority Registry
- 4.7.2 Layer 2 artifacts **MUST** be:
- Explicit and unambiguous
 - Versioned
 - Accessible to all members
- 4.7.3 Absence, ambiguity, or systematic violation of Layer 2 artifacts **MUST** result in loss of RCOS-Core compliance.

Layer 3 — Economic & Resource System

Layer 3 defines how value, resources, and obligations flow inside the community. Its purpose is to make economic power explicit, bounded, reviewable, and subordinate to governance, preventing hidden accumulation, dependency, or coercion.

5.1 Commons vs Private Resources

- 5.1.1 All resources within the declared governed scope **MUST** be explicitly classified as either **commons** or **private**.
- 5.1.2 The community **MUST** maintain a single, explicit, and versioned registry of governed resources, including at minimum:
 - Resource name or unique identifier
 - Classification (commons or private)
 - Steward or owner (as applicable)
 - Access and use rules
 - Transfer, sale, or privatization constraints (if any)
- 5.1.3 Any resource not explicitly classified **MUST** be treated as **unclassified**, and the community **MUST NOT** allocate, encumber, monetize, or transfer it until classification is completed through an authorized decision.
- 5.1.4 For commons resources, the community **MUST** explicitly define:
 - Stewardship responsibilities
 - The authorized decision-making body or role
 - Maintenance obligations
 - Funding or contribution mechanisms (if any)
- 5.1.5 For private resources, the community **MUST NOT** exercise authority beyond what is explicitly declared in the scope, membership agreements, or other governed artifacts.

5.2 Contribution Recognition

- 5.2.1 The community **MUST** explicitly define which contribution categories are recognized. These **MAY** include, but are not limited to:
- Labor
 - Care and emotional work
 - Knowledge and education
 - Stewardship and maintenance
 - Administrative or coordination work
- 5.2.2 The community **MUST** define a contribution recognition mechanism specifying:
- What qualifies as a contribution
 - How contributions are recorded or acknowledged
 - Who may record, validate, or contest contributions
 - Whether and how contribution recognition affects access to resources, privileges, or obligations
- 5.2.3 The community **MUST NOT** structurally depend on unpaid, invisible, or informal labor for system survival without explicitly defining corresponding obligations, recognition, or compensation mechanisms.
- 5.2.4 If internal economic units are used (e.g. time credits, points, tokens), the Internal Economy Protocol **MUST** define:
- Issuance rules
 - Transferability rules
 - Expiration, decay, or cap mechanisms (if any)
 - Fraud prevention, dispute handling, and correction mechanisms
 - Privacy and transparency rules for balances and transactions
- 5.2.5 Contribution recognition **MUST NOT** create implicit decision authority, veto power, or governance influence beyond what is defined in Layer 2.

5.3 Treasury Management

- 5.3.1 The community **MUST** explicitly define which resources are held in the shared treasury and how treasury boundaries interface with private resources.
- 5.3.2 Income sources and any external income interfaces **MUST** be explicitly defined.
- 5.3.3 Spending authority **MUST** be explicitly bounded through:
- Clear authority assignments
 - Thresholds by amount and/or category
 - Approval and escalation paths
 - Mandatory recordkeeping requirements
- 5.3.4 Transparency **MUST** be the default for treasury balances, inflows, outflows, obligations, and commitments.
- 5.3.5 Any exceptions to transparency **MUST** be explicitly defined, justified, time-bounded, and **MUST NOT** prevent members from auditing compliance.
- 5.3.6 The community **MUST** define reserve, risk, and liability policies, including:
- Limits on debt
 - Long-term obligations
 - Contingency reserves (if any)

5.4 Accumulation Constraints

- 5.4.1 Internal economic systems **MUST** prevent unbounded concentration of internal influence or control through resources, credits, or financial obligations.

- 5.4.2 If internal units exist, the community **MUST** define one or more accumulation-limiting mechanisms, which **MAY** include:
- Caps
 - Decay or expiration
 - Non-transferability
 - Redistribution or taxation mechanisms
 - Time-bounded validity
- 5.4.3 Economic mechanisms **MUST NOT** allow members to bypass governance authority boundaries defined in Layer 2, including through purchasing influence, creating dependency, or converting economic power into informal decision authority.
- 5.4.4 The community **MUST** define reviewable indicators of economic concentration risk and an explicit mechanism to adjust constraints when such risks are detected.

5.5 Artifacts

- 5.5.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 3 compliance:
- Internal Economy Protocol
 - Treasury Ruleset
- 5.5.2 Layer 3 artifacts **MUST** be:
- Explicit and unambiguous
 - Versioned
 - Accessible to all members (with explicit, bounded exceptions)
 - Adopted through an authorized governance process
- 5.5.3 The Internal Economy Protocol **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Contribution categories and recognition mechanisms
 - Commons vs private boundaries and allocation rules
 - Internal units (if any) and accumulation constraints
 - External income interfaces (if any)
 - Dispute resolution and correction mechanisms for economic records

5.5.4 The Treasury Ruleset **MUST** define, at minimum:

- Income sources
- Spending authority thresholds and approval paths
- Transparency and reporting requirements (including any bounded exceptions)
- Reserve, risk, and debt constraints
- Conflict-of-interest rules for spending and procurement

5.6 Layer Invariants

5.6.1 Shared resources, flows, and obligations **MUST** be visible to the community by default, with only limited and explicit exceptions.

5.6.2 Resources declared as commons **MUST NOT** be privatized through informal, implicit, or unilateral action.

5.6.3 Contribution recognition **MUST** be explicit such that unpaid or invisible labor is not structurally required for system survival.

5.6.4 Economic mechanisms **MUST** prevent indefinite concentration of internal influence.

5.7 Explicitness Rules

5.7.1 The following **MUST** be explicit:

- Commons vs private classifications
- Allocation and access rules for shared resources
- Spending authority limits
- Transparency rules
- External income interfaces

5.7.2 The following **MAY** be explicit:

- Contribution valuation models
- Internal units (tokens, hours, points)
- Budget categories and internal accounting structures

5.7.3 The following **MUST** remain optional and out of scope:

- Attitudes toward wealth
- Equal vs differentiated outcomes
- Personal financial choices

Layer 4 – Conflict, Repair & Accountability

Layer 4 defines how the community responds when trust, coordination, or safety breaks down.

Its purpose is to ensure conflicts are handled explicitly, fairly, and safely, while preventing abuse of power, normalization of harm, or silent exclusion.

6.1 Conflict Classification

- 6.1.1 The community **MUST** define an explicit conflict classification system that is known, accessible, and usable by all members.
- 6.1.2 At minimum, the classification system **MUST** include the following classes:
- Interpersonal conflicts (between individuals)
 - Role-based conflicts (authority, responsibility, or mandate disputes)
 - Structural conflicts (systemic incentives, rules, or resource allocation issues)
 - Ethical or boundary violations (violations of declared norms, scope, or safety boundaries)
- 6.1.3 Each conflict class **MUST** explicitly define:
- Entry criteria (how a situation is classified into this class)
 - Expected response priority and timelines (if any)
 - Permitted and required resolution pathways
 - Documentation requirements and privacy boundaries
- 6.1.4 Conflicts involving credible safety risks, coercion, abuse, or threats **MUST** be classified as **safety-critical** and **MUST** trigger elevated safeguards as defined in Section 6.3.
- 6.1.5 Misclassification or avoidance of classification **MUST** be treated as a process failure subject to review.

6.2 Resolution Pathways

- 6.2.1 The community **MUST** define a minimum conflict resolution process applicable to all conflict classes.
- 6.2.2 The resolution process **MUST** include a clearly defined **resolution ladder** with explicit escalation steps.
- 6.2.3 The resolution ladder **MUST** define, at minimum:
- How a conflict is raised, logged, and acknowledged
 - How involved parties are notified and invited to participate
 - How refusal, non-response, or withdrawal is handled
 - How mediators or facilitators are selected, replaced, or declined
 - Time-bounded expectations for each stage (where applicable)
 - Documentation requirements and access rules
 - A process for reviewing procedural failures or deadlock
- 6.2.4 The resolution process **MUST** be accessible without requiring social status, seniority, charisma, or informal proximity to decision-makers.
- 6.2.5 Unresolved conflicts **MUST** escalate through defined governance pathways without bypassing the Decision Matrix defined in [Layer 2](#).

6.3 Safeguards

- 6.3.1 The community **MUST** define explicit safeguards for conflicts involving power asymmetries, dependency relationships, or safety risks.
- 6.3.2 Safeguards **MUST** include protections against retaliation for:
- Raising a concern
 - Requesting mediation
 - Providing testimony or evidence
 - Participating in a review or appeal

- 6.3.3 Where a power differential exists between parties, elevated safeguards **MUST** be applied, which **MAY** include:
- Independent or external facilitation
 - Separate intake, documentation, or communication channels
 - Temporary suspension or limitation of role authority
 - Additional evidence and review thresholds prior to sanctions
- 6.3.4 For safety-critical conflicts, the community **MUST** define immediate protective actions that may be taken prior to full process completion, which **MAY** include:
- Temporary separation measures
 - Restricted access to shared spaces or resources
 - Temporary role suspension
 - Emergency escalation timelines
- 6.3.5 Safety safeguards **MUST** override participation rights, role continuity, and operational convenience.

6.4 Sanctions, Repair, and Separation

- 6.4.1 The community **MUST** define an explicit sanctions and repair framework.
- 6.4.2 Sanctions and repair actions **MUST** be:
- Proportional to the violation
 - Explicitly documented
 - Time-bounded where applicable
 - Reviewable and appealable
- 6.4.3 The framework **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Available sanction and repair types
 - Preconditions and evidence standards
 - Authorized roles or bodies for application
 - Review and appeal mechanisms
 - Conditions for restoring rights, roles, or participation

- 6.4.4 Separation, suspension, or removal actions **MUST** follow due process and **MUST** align with exit and separation rules defined in Layer 1.
- 6.4.5 Sanctions **MUST NOT** be applied through informal exclusion, social pressure, silence, or implicit withdrawal of rights.
- 6.4.6 Repair-oriented actions **MUST** be prioritized over punitive actions except in safety-critical cases.

6.5 Artifacts

- 6.5.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 4 compliance:
- Conflict Resolution Ladder
 - Accountability Protocol
- 6.5.2 Layer 4 artifacts **MUST** be:
- Explicit and unambiguous
 - Versioned
 - Accessible to all members, with clearly bounded privacy protections
 - Adopted through an authorized governance process
- 6.5.3 The Conflict Resolution Ladder **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Conflict classification inputs and escalation thresholds
 - Resolution stages and facilitator selection rules
 - Documentation and information access boundaries
 - Safety-critical exceptions and immediate safeguards
- 6.5.4 The Accountability Protocol **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Investigation, review, and decision mechanisms
 - Due process guarantees and anti-retaliation protections
 - Sanction and repair options with proportionality rules
 - Appeals, oversight, and escalation paths
 - Coordination with Layer 1 exit and separation processes

6.6 Layer Invariants

- 6.6.1 Conflict **MUST** be treated as a handled condition with defined pathways; ignoring, suppressing, or normalizing unresolved conflict **MUST** be considered a system violation.
- 6.6.2 Conflicts involving power asymmetries **MUST** trigger elevated safeguards.
- 6.6.3 Repair and restoration **MUST** precede punishment except where immediate safety is at risk.
- 6.6.4 Physical, psychological, and child safety **MUST** override participation rights, role continuity, and reputational concerns.

6.7 Explicitness Rules

- 6.7.1 The following **MUST** be explicit:
 - Conflict classification system
 - Minimum resolution and escalation process
 - Safeguards and anti-retaliation protections
 - Sanction, repair, and separation thresholds
- 6.7.2 The following **MAY** be explicit:
 - Mediation styles or methodologies
 - Facilitator selection preferences beyond minimum safeguards
 - Restorative or reparative practices
- 6.7.3 The following **MUST** remain optional and out of scope:
 - Emotional expression norms
 - Therapeutic, spiritual, or ideological framing of conflict

Layer 5 – Operations & Coordination

Layer 5 defines how daily work, coordination, and information flow function in practice.

Its purpose is to ensure that operations remain legible, sustainable, and transferable, and do not collapse into informal hierarchy, dependency, or burnout.

7.1 Roles and Responsibilities

- 7.1.1 All ongoing responsibilities **MUST** be assigned to explicit, named roles rather than implicit expectations or informal agreements.
- 7.1.2 The community **MUST** maintain a **Role Registry** that includes, at minimum:
 - Role name and purpose
 - Scope of responsibility and decision authority
 - Explicit boundaries and interfaces with other roles, circles, or domains
 - Eligibility criteria (if any)
 - Term length, rotation, or review conditions (if any)
 - Appointment, review, and removal process
- 7.1.3 Each role **MUST** include an explicit accountability mechanism defining:
 - How role performance is reviewed
 - How underperformance, overload, or role failure is handled
 - How handover and knowledge transfer occur
- 7.1.4 No ongoing responsibility **MAY** exist without an explicit role, and no person **MAY** be held accountable for responsibilities not formally assigned to a role.
- 7.1.5 Temporary or ad-hoc responsibilities **MUST** be explicitly time-bounded and **MUST NOT** become ongoing without formal role definition.

7.2 Meeting System

- 7.2.1 The community **MUST** define explicit meeting types sufficient to support:
- Operations
 - Governance
 - Coordination and alignment
 - Reflection and learning
 - Conflict handling (as required by [Layer 4](#))
- 7.2.2 Each meeting type **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Purpose and decision scope
 - Required vs optional participants
 - Cadence and duration boundaries
 - Facilitation role and selection or rotation process
 - Agenda structure
 - Documentation and publication requirements
 - Decision capture requirements where decisions are made
- 7.2.3 Meetings **MUST NOT** exceed their declared decision scope or bypass authority boundaries defined in [Layer 2](#).
- 7.2.4 Meeting load **MUST** be bounded, monitored, and reviewable as defined in Section 7.4.

7.3 Documentation and Information Flow

- 7.3.1 The community **MUST** define explicit documentation rules for decisions, roles, operations, and shared obligations.
- 7.3.2 Documentation rules **MUST** specify, at minimum:
- What information **MUST** be recorded
 - Where records are stored
 - Who has access to which records
 - Publication or notification timelines (if any)
 - Privacy boundaries and conditions for restricted access

- 7.3.3 All decisions **MUST** be traceable to:
- Decision type and domain
 - Authorized role or body
 - Decision mechanism and threshold
 - Recorded outcome and effective date
- 7.3.4 Critical operational processes **MUST** be documented such that continuity does not depend on tacit knowledge held by specific individuals.
- 7.3.5 Information flow **MUST** be designed to prevent gatekeeping, bottlenecks, or dependency on informal intermediaries.

7.4 Workload and Capacity Boundaries

- 7.4.1 Time, attention, coordination capacity, and emotional labor **MUST** be treated as finite and limited resources.
- 7.4.2 The community **MUST** define explicit workload boundaries, including:
- Limits on meeting load (frequency, duration, or total time)
 - Limits on role load (number of roles, scope, or expected hours)
 - Expectations for response times and availability (if any)
 - Mechanisms for renegotiation, relief, substitution, or redistribution
- 7.4.3 Workload boundaries **MUST** be reviewable and adjustable through an authorized governance process.
- 7.4.4 Persistent overload, burnout risk, chronic non-participation, or dependency on over-functioning individuals **MUST** trigger review or repair processes as defined in [Layer 4](#).

7.5 Operational Continuity

- 7.5.1 The community **MUST** ensure that no single individual is a critical single point of failure for core operations.

- 7.5.2 Core operational roles and processes **MUST** include:
- Documented procedures
 - Clear handover mechanisms
 - Backup or redundancy arrangements where feasible
- 7.5.3 Operational continuity planning **MUST** be reviewed periodically.

7.6 Artifacts

- 7.6.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 5 compliance:
- Operations Manual
 - Role Registry
 - Meeting Templates
- 7.6.2 Layer 5 artifacts **MUST** be:
- Explicit and unambiguous
 - Versioned
 - Accessible to all members, with clearly bounded privacy protections
 - Maintained as living documents with defined ownership and review cycles
- 7.6.3 The Operations Manual **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Core operational processes relied upon by the community
 - Interfaces between roles, domains, and meeting types
 - Documentation locations and update procedures
- 7.6.4 Meeting Templates **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Agenda structure
 - Notes and record format
 - Decision capture format where applicable

7.7 Layer Invariants

- 7.7.1 Ongoing responsibilities **MUST NOT** exist without an explicit role.

- 7.7.2 Critical operational processes **MUST NOT** rely solely on individual memory, goodwill, or informal transmission.
- 7.7.3 Meeting load, coordination burden, and unpaid or invisible labor **MUST** be bounded and reviewable.
- 7.7.4 Information access rules **MUST** be explicit and enforceable.

7.8 Explicitness Rules

- 7.8.1 The following **MUST** be explicit:
- Roles and responsibilities
 - Operational authority boundaries and interfaces
 - Meeting types and scopes
 - Decision documentation rules
 - Information access and privacy boundaries
- 7.8.2 The following **MAY** be explicit:
- Detailed meeting cadence beyond minimum constraints
 - Tooling choices for documentation and coordination
 - Role rotation or succession schedules
- 7.8.3 The following **MUST** remain optional and out of scope:
- Personal work styles
 - Aesthetic or cultural preferences
 - Informal social coordination

Layer 6 — Evolution & Adaptation

Layer 6 defines how the system evolves without collapsing.

Its purpose is to ensure that change is deliberate, constrained, reversible where appropriate, and produces learnings rather than hidden damage. Evolution under RCOS is treated as a governed process, not as improvisation.

8.1 Change Mechanisms

- 8.1.1 The community **MUST** define explicit change mechanisms for modifying, adding, suspending, or removing rules, roles, artifacts, or decision structures.
- 8.1.2 Change mechanisms **MUST** explicitly distinguish between:
 - Permanent rule changes
 - Time-bounded experiments as defined in Section 8.3
- 8.1.3 Every proposed change **MUST** specify, at minimum:
 - The artifact(s), layer(s), and section(s) affected
 - The decision type and authorized decision path as defined in [Layer 2](#)
 - The intended effect, scope, and known risks
 - The effective date and any transition period
 - Migration requirements for existing roles, agreements, or records
- 8.1.4 Changes affecting [Layer 0](#) purpose, scope, invariants, or identity constraints **MUST** be classified as constitutional changes and **MUST** follow the constitutional decision mechanism.
- 8.1.5 The community **MUST** define explicit review mechanisms for adopted changes, including how changes are evaluated, revised, or reverted when they produce harm, instability, or unintended concentration of power.

8.2 Versioning and Authority

- 8.2.1 All adopted changes **MUST** be versioned and traceable.

- 8.2.2 The community **MUST** maintain a **Version History** that records, at minimum:
- Version identifier
 - Adoption date and effective date
 - Decision record reference (authority, mechanism, threshold)
 - Summary of changes
 - Migration notes and compatibility constraints (if any)
- 8.2.3 At any point in time, the community **MUST** be able to unambiguously determine:
- Which version is currently in force
 - Which artifacts are authoritative for compliance
- 8.2.4 Superseded rules **MUST** remain accessible for auditability, learning, and dispute resolution, together with the dates during which they were in force.
- 8.2.5 No informal, undocumented, or “understood” rule changes **MAY** be considered valid.

8.3 Experiments

- 8.3.1 The community **MAY** adopt experiments as explicitly time-bounded and reversible deviations, extensions, or pilots intended for learning.
- 8.3.2 Every experiment **MUST** define, at minimum:
- Scope (what is changed and what is explicitly not changed)
 - Duration and review checkpoints
 - Success and failure criteria
 - Rollback conditions and rollback process
 - Authorized decision path for starting, extending, modifying, or terminating the experiment
- 8.3.3 Experiments **MUST NOT** override Layer 0 invariants and **MUST NOT** bypass governance constraints defined in Layer 2.
- 8.3.4 Experiments **MUST** be explicitly labeled as experimental in all affected artifacts and **MUST** include a non-extendable expiration date unless renewed through an authorized decision.

- 8.3.5 If an experiment introduces safety risk, coercion, or sustained harm, the community **MUST** suspend or terminate the experiment immediately through a protective action, followed by post-hoc review.

8.4 Learning and Feedback Capture

- 8.4.1 Major failures, adaptations, reversals, and systemic learnings **MUST** be documented.
- 8.4.2 Learning capture **MUST** include, at minimum:
- What occurred and why it mattered
 - Which layers, rules, or artifacts were implicated
 - What was changed, attempted, or stopped
 - What signals, evidence, or thresholds triggered action
- 8.4.3 Learning records **MUST** be accessible according to Layer 5 information access rules.
- 8.4.4 Repeated failure patterns **MUST** trigger structural review rather than individual blame.

8.5 Change Safety and Reversibility

- 8.5.1 The system **MUST** prefer reversible changes over irreversible ones where possible.
- 8.5.2 Irreversible or high-impact changes **MUST** include:
- Extended deliberation or review periods
 - Higher decision thresholds where appropriate
 - Explicit risk acknowledgment
- 8.5.3 Emergency changes **MAY** be permitted only where explicitly defined, **MUST** be time-bounded, **MUST NOT** override Layer 0 invariants, and **MUST** undergo mandatory post-hoc review and ratification or rollback.

8.6 Artifacts

8.6.1 The following artifacts are mandatory for Layer 6 compliance:

- Change Protocol
- Version History
- Learning Log

8.6.2 Layer 6 artifacts **MUST** be:

- Explicit and unambiguous
- Versioned
- Accessible to all members, with clearly bounded privacy protections
- Adopted through an authorized governance process

8.6.3 The Change Protocol **MUST** define, at minimum:

- How changes are proposed, reviewed, adopted, published, and rejected
- How proposals are classified by decision type
- Required contents of change proposals
- Transition, migration, and deprecation expectations
- Review, revision, and rollback mechanisms
- Emergency change provisions, including strict time bounds and mandatory review

8.6.4 The Version History **MUST** define:

- The authoritative structure for version identifiers and change logs
- How superseded versions are retained and accessed
- How the currently active version is determined

8.6.5 The Learning Log **MUST** define:

- What constitutes a learnable event
- Documentation format and ownership
- Review and synthesis cadence

8.7 Layer Invariants

- 8.7.1 Change **MUST** be possible but constrained; no change **MAY** be instantaneous, implicit, or unreviewable.
- 8.7.2 All adopted changes **MUST** be versioned, documented, and traceable.
- 8.7.3 Experiments **MUST** be time-bounded, explicitly labeled, and reversible.
- 8.7.4 Major failures and adaptations **MUST** be captured as shared learning, not erased or hidden.

8.8 Explicitness Rules

- 8.8.1 The following **MUST** be explicit:
 - How rules change and who decides
 - Versioning, authority, and review processes
 - Experiment scope, duration, and rollback conditions
 - Emergency change conditions and limits
- 8.8.2 The following **MAY** be explicit:
 - Review frequency and cadence
 - Sunset clauses
 - Feedback and sensing methods
- 8.8.3 The following **MUST** remain optional and out of scope:
 - Pace of innovation
 - Cultural attitudes toward risk within defined bounds

Non-Normative Sections

The sections in this chapter are **informative**, not normative.

They do not define compliance requirements but provide guidance, context, examples, and learning support for communities, implementers, auditors, and standard stewards.

Nothing in this section may override or weaken requirements defined in Layers 0–6.

9.1 Optional Modules

9.1.1 Optional Modules are domain-specific extensions that build on top of RCOS-Core without modifying its mandatory layers.

9.1.2 Optional Modules **MUST** :

- Declare which RCOS layers they extend or depend on
- Explicitly state any additional roles, rules, or artifacts they introduce
- NOT override or contradict Layer 0 invariants or RCOS-Core requirements

9.1.3 Optional Modules **MAY** define:

- Domain-specific practices
- Additional constraints or standards
- Specialized governance or operational patterns

9.1.4 Typical Optional Module domains **MAY** include, but are not limited to:

- Permaculture and regenerative land stewardship
- Alternative or community-based education systems
- Health, care, and well-being practices
- Cultural or spiritual practices
- Economic specializations (e.g. cooperatives, land trusts, mutual credit)

9.1.5 Adoption of Optional Modules **MUST** follow the change mechanisms defined in Layer 6.

9.1.6 A community **MAY** be RCOS-Core compliant without adopting any Optional Modules.

9.2 Reference Implementations

- 9.2.1 A Reference Implementation is a real-world community that publicly documents how it applies RCOS-Core.
- 9.2.2 Reference Implementations are **descriptive**, not prescriptive. They illustrate how RCOS can be instantiated, not how it must be instantiated.
- 9.2.3 A community **MAY** claim to be an RCOS Reference Implementation only if it:
- Is RCOS-Core compliant
 - Publicly documents its **Layer 0**–6 artifacts
 - Clearly indicates deviations, experiments, or extensions
- 9.2.4 Reference Implementation documentation **SHOULD** include:
- Context and scale (size, location, purpose)
 - Which Optional Modules are adopted
 - Known challenges and failures
 - Evolution history and major adaptations
- 9.2.5 Reference Implementations **MUST NOT** be treated as authoritative interpretations of the standard.

9.3 Known Failure Modes

- 9.3.1 Known Failure Modes document recurring breakdown patterns observed in real communities.
- 9.3.2 Failure Modes are **informative signals**, not compliance criteria.

9.3.3 Failure Modes **MAY** include, but are not limited to:

- Informal power accumulation
- Founder or land-owner dominance
- Invisible or gendered labor dependency
- Governance paralysis or meeting overload
- Exit blockage or soft coercion
- Economic capture through debt or asset control
- Conflict avoidance leading to silent fragmentation

9.3.4 The purpose of documenting Failure Modes is to:

- Support stress-testing of RCOS structures
- Improve design decisions
- Enable early detection in live communities

9.3.5 Failure Mode documentation **SHOULD** reference which RCOS layers are intended to mitigate the pattern.

Compliance & Auditing

This chapter defines how RCOS-Core compliance is assessed and maintained.

10.1 Compliance Checklist

- 10.1.1 RCOS-Core compliance is binary: a community is either compliant or non-compliant.
- 10.1.2 Compliance **MUST** be evaluated per layer (Layers 0–6).
- 10.1.3 For each layer, the Compliance Checklist **MUST** verify:
 - Presence of mandatory artifacts
 - Explicitness and accessibility of required rules
 - Adoption through authorized governance processes
- 10.1.4 Partial compliance or “intent to comply” **MUST NOT** be considered compliant.
- 10.1.5 Optional Modules **MUST NOT** be included in RCOS-Core compliance evaluation.

10.2 Test Cases

- 10.2.1 Test Cases are structured scenarios used to validate whether RCOS mechanisms behave as intended.
- 10.2.2 Test Cases **MAY** be:
 - Hypothetical scenarios
 - Historical community failures
 - Simulated stress tests

10.2.3 Test Cases **SHOULD** cover, at minimum:

- Power concentration attempts
- Exit and separation scenarios
- Governance deadlock
- Economic capture attempts
- Safety-critical conflicts

10.2.4 Test Cases are informative but **SHOULD** be used during audits, onboarding, and periodic reviews.

10.3 Non-Compliance

10.3.1 A community **MUST** be considered non-compliant if:

- Any mandatory artifact is missing
- Layer 0 invariants are violated
- Decisions are repeatedly made outside authorized governance structures
- Exit is blocked or informally constrained

10.3.2 Non-compliance **MUST** be explicitly acknowledged once detected.

10.3.3 A community **MAY** regain compliance only through:

- Corrective action
- Formal adoption of missing or corrected artifacts
- Documentation of remediation

10.3.4 Claims of RCOS compliance **MUST** be withdrawn during periods of known non-compliance.

Versioning & Governance of the Standard

This chapter defines how RCOS itself evolves as a standard.

11.1 Standard Stewardship

- 11.1.1 RCOS **MUST** have an identifiable stewarding body or process.
- 11.1.2 The steward's responsibilities **MUST** include:
 - Maintaining the canonical specification
 - Managing version releases
 - Curating reference materials and learning
 - Protecting Layer 0 invariants of the standard itself
- 11.1.3 The steward **MUST NOT** act as an enforcement authority over communities.
- 11.1.4 RCOS stewardship **MUST** prioritize clarity, stability, and real-world learnings over ideological purity.

11.2 Change Process

- 11.2.1 Changes to RCOS-Core **MUST** follow a defined change process.
- 11.2.2 The change process **MUST** include:
 - Proposal submission
 - Public review and feedback period
 - Decision mechanism and authority
 - Versioning and publication
- 11.2.3 Backward compatibility **SHOULD** be preserved where possible.
- 11.2.4 Breaking changes **MUST** be clearly marked and justified.
- 11.2.5 Superseded versions of RCOS **MUST** remain publicly accessible.
- 11.2.6 RCOS itself **MUST** model the same principles it requires of communities: explicitness, bounded authority, reversibility, and learning.

Appendix A – Glossary

This glossary provides **informative definitions** for key terms used throughout the RCOS specification.

Glossary entries do not introduce new requirements and do not override normative sections.

Accountability

The expectation that roles and members can be asked to explain actions, outcomes, and adherence to agreed rules, with defined review and correction mechanisms.

Accountability Protocol

An artifact defining how violations, harms, or repeated failures are reviewed, documented, and addressed, including due process, safeguards, and escalation paths.

Artifact

A documented, versioned object (e.g. protocol, registry, charter) adopted through an authorized process and used to operationalize RCOS layers.

Authority Boundary

The explicit limits within which a role, circle, or body may make decisions or act.

Change Protocol

An artifact defining how changes are proposed, reviewed, adopted, published, and rolled back, including decision type classification and emergency provisions.

Commons

Resources governed collectively under explicit stewardship, access, and decision rules.

Community

A group of people who voluntarily coordinate around a shared purpose within a defined scope and governance system.

Compliance

The state of meeting all mandatory requirements of RCOS-Core across Layers 0–6.

Conflict Resolution Ladder

A staged conflict process defining minimum resolution steps and escalation thresholds, from low-intensity repair to governance review and, if necessary, separation.

Constitutional Decision

A decision that modifies Layer 0 purpose, scope, invariants, or identity constraints, or the governance system itself.

Decision Matrix

A governance artifact mapping decision types and domains to authorized roles, mechanisms, thresholds, and escalation paths.

Decision Type

A classification of decisions (Operational, Strategic, Constitutional) used to determine authority and process.

Due Process

The minimum fairness guarantees required before restricting rights, applying sanctions, or triggering separation, including notice, review, and appeal pathways as defined.

Emergency Change

A time-bounded change enacted under explicitly defined emergency conditions, requiring post-hoc review and ratification or rollback.

Explicit

Written, adopted, accessible, and reviewable.

Anything not explicit is treated as non-existent under RCOS.

Explicitness Rule

The principle that mechanisms allocating power, risk, responsibility, or exit conditions must be written, adopted, and reviewable.

Experiment

A time-bounded, reversible change adopted for learning and evaluation.

Exit & Separation Protocol

An artifact defining voluntary exit, forced exit due process, and separation of assets, roles, access, and obligations.

Governance Protocol

An artifact defining the decision lifecycle (proposal, deliberation, adoption, documentation, review) and how governance conflicts are resolved.

In-Scope / Out-of-Scope

In-scope refers to people, assets, domains, and activities explicitly governed by the community. Out-of-scope refers to everything explicitly excluded or not declared in scope.

Internal Economy Protocol

An artifact defining contribution recognition and any internal exchange mechanisms, including accumulation constraints and dispute correction.

Invariant

A non-negotiable constraint that cannot be overridden while it is in force.

Layer

A functional domain of RCOS that defines a specific aspect of community operation.

Learning Log

An artifact capturing major failures, adaptations, reversals, and lessons learned, including triggers, affected artifacts, and outcomes.

Member

A person who has explicitly entered the community through the defined membership process.

Optional Module

A domain-specific extension that builds on RCOS-Core without altering its mandatory layers.

Registry

An artifact that records a set of authoritative entries (e.g., roles, resources, membership states) with clear ownership, update rules, and version history.

Reference Implementation

A real-world community that publicly documents its application of RCOS-Core.

Role

An explicitly defined bundle of responsibilities, authority, and accountability, independent of the person holding it.

Safety-Critical

A condition where physical, psychological, or child safety is at risk, requiring elevated safeguards and potentially immediate protective action.

Sanction

A defined, documented restriction or corrective action applied through authorized process, proportionate to a violation and subject to review.

Scope

The explicitly declared domains, assets, and activities over which the community exercises authority.

Stewardship

Responsibility for care, maintenance, and governance of a resource within defined boundaries.

Treasury

The set of shared resources, balances, obligations, and commitments held under collective rules.

Treasury Ruleset

An artifact defining how treasury resources are held, spent, reported, audited, and constrained, including thresholds and conflict-of-interest rules.

Transparency Exception

An explicitly defined, justified, time-bounded limitation on information access that still permits compliance auditing.

Version History

An artifact recording which version is in force and documenting adopted changes, effective dates, and decision references.

Appendix B – Example Artifacts (Non-Normative)

This appendix provides illustrative examples of artifacts referenced in the specification.

Examples are informative only and should not be treated as required formats or implementations.

B.1 Example Purpose Charter (Excerpt)

- Primary purpose (singular): “Maintain and steward a shared, regenerative living place that provides stable housing and ecological restoration.”
- Secondary purposes (bounded):
 - “Operate a small educational program on regenerative practices.”
 - “Run a member-owned cooperative for local food production.”
- Non-goals / exclusions:
 - “Not a political party.”
 - “Not a short-term project collective.”
 - “Not a for-profit real estate vehicle.”
- Conditions for purpose change:
 - “Purpose changes require a constitutional decision and full re-ratification.”
- Ratification record:
 - Adopted: 2026-01-01
 - Decision type: Constitutional
 - Version: 0.3
 - Decision record link: [placeholder]

B.2 Example Scope Declaration (Excerpt)

- In-scope assets:
 - Land parcel “North Field”
 - Buildings: “Common House”, “Workshop”
 - Shared funds: operating treasury, reserve fund
 - Shared infrastructure: water system, solar array, shared vehicles
- In-scope authority domains:
 - Governance rules and decision process (Layer 2)
 - Membership rules and states (Layer 1)
 - Treasury and shared resource allocation (Layer 3)
 - Operational coordination for shared work (Layer 5)
- Out-of-scope domains:
 - Personal income, private debt, and private bank accounts
 - Private relationships and private living spaces (except safety-critical conditions)
 - Off-site businesses not using community assets

B.3 Example Decision Matrix (Excerpt)

Decision Domain	Decision Type	Authorized Body	Mechanism	Threshold	Escalation
Budget approval (annual)	Strategic	Finance Circle	Consent	No objections	General Circle
Emergency spend ≤ 500	Operational	Treasurer	Delegated authority	N/A	Finance Circle

Decision Domain	Decision Type	Authorized Body	Mechanism	Threshold	Escalation
Spend 501–5,000	Strategic	Finance Circle	Vote	Majority	General Circle
Add/remove a core invariant	Constitutional	General Circle	Vote	Supermajority (80%)	Constitutional review
Role appointment	Operational	Circle Lead	Consent	No objections	Governance Circle

B4 Example Internal Economy Protocol (Excerpt)

- Recognized contribution categories:
 - Labor (maintenance, construction, food production)
 - Care (childcare, elder care, conflict support)
 - Knowledge (training, documentation, facilitation)
 - Stewardship (resource maintenance, procurement oversight)
- Recording mechanism:
 - Weekly contribution log submitted by members
 - Monthly review by the Operations Circle for consistency and corrections
- Internal units (optional):
 - “Time credits” tracked in hours for certain shared allocations
- Accumulation constraints (if internal units exist):
 - Caps on balance
 - Expiration after 12 months unless renewed by review
- Dispute and correction:
 - Any member may request review of a record within 30 days
 - Corrections require documented rationale and are logged in a change history

B.5 Example Conflict Resolution Ladder (Excerpt)

1. Direct conversation (informal repair)
2. Facilitated mediation (neutral facilitator selected from an approved list)
3. Accountability intake (documented intake; anti-retaliation safeguards activated)
4. Accountability review (findings, repair plan, and proportional responses)
5. Governance decision (if authority, access, or roles must change)
6. Separation process (if required; coordinated with Layer 1 exit and separation protocol)

B.6 Example Change Proposal Template (Excerpt)

- Change title:
- Summary (1–3 sentences):
- Affected layers and artifacts (links):
- Change type:
 - Permanent change / Experiment
- Decision type and authorized decision path (Decision Matrix reference):
- Rationale:
- Risks and mitigations:
- Transition and migration plan:
- Rollback plan and rollback triggers:
- Effective date and review date:

B.7 Example Membership Agreement (Excerpt)

- Membership state on signing: Trial / Full
- Member rights (examples):

- Access to the decision records defined as transparent
- Participation rights according to decision type
- A defined exit pathway at all times
- Member obligations (examples):
 - Contribution expectations as defined by role and membership state
 - Adherence to declared invariants and safety rules
 - Participation in minimum onboarding and review processes
- Due process reference:
 - “Any forced exit or access restriction follows Layer 4 due process and the exit protocol.”

B.8 Example Onboarding Protocol (Excerpt)

1. Provide access to RCOS artifacts (Layers 0–6) and local modules
2. Confirm explicit consent to Layer 0 and Layer 1 artifacts
3. Assign initial membership state and onboarding buddy
4. Complete safety and conflict process orientation
5. Review scope boundaries and what is out of scope
6. Record onboarding completion in the membership registry

B.9 Example Role Registry Entry (Excerpt)

- Role name: Treasurer
- Purpose: Maintain treasury records and execute authorized payments
- Authority scope:
 - Execute payments ≤ 500 within approved categories
- Limits:

- No authority to approve budgets or alter transparency rules
- Term:
 - 6 months, renewable once without review
- Accountability:
 - Monthly published treasury report; quarterly audit check
- Appointment/removal:
 - Appointed by Finance Circle; removable by Governance Circle review

B.10 Example Treasury Ruleset (Excerpt)

- Transparency:
 - Monthly balance sheet and cash-flow summary published to all members
- Spending thresholds:

Amount	Decision Type	Authorized Body	Mechanism
≤ 500	Operational	Treasurer	Delegated
501–5,000	Strategic	Finance Circle	Majority vote
> 5,000	Strategic	General Circle	Majority vote
Debt / long-term obligation	Constitutional	General Circle	Supermajority

- Conflict-of-interest:
 - A requester may not approve their own spending request

B.11 Example Meeting Template (Excerpt)

- Meeting type: Operations
- Date/time:

- Facilitator:
- Attendees:
- Agenda:
 1. Check-ins (time-boxed)
 2. Review last actions
 3. Operational updates
 4. Decisions (if any)
 5. Next actions and owners
- Decision record (if used):
 - Decision type:
 - Authority:
 - Mechanism/threshold:
 - Outcome:
 - Effective date:

B.12 Example Learning Log Entry (Excerpt)

- Date:
- Trigger event:
- What happened (short narrative):
- Layers/artifacts implicated:
- Signals that triggered action:
- What changed (or what was tried):
- Outcome after review:
- Follow-up action owner and due date:

Appendix C – Reference Implementation Summary

This appendix defines a **recommended documentation structure** for communities that wish to present themselves as RCOS Reference Implementations. The goal is to make adoption auditable, comparable, and learnable without implying endorsement.

C.1 Community Context

- Name and location
- Size and scale (e.g., 12 members; 3 households; 25 hectares)
- Primary purpose (Layer 0)
- Date of founding and date of RCOS adoption (if different)
- Relevant legal form(s) (if any)
- Public contact point

C.2 RCOS Adoption Overview

- RCOS-Core version in use
- Adoption decision record reference (authority, mechanism, date)
- Summary of adopted Optional Modules (if any), including:
 - Module name and scope
 - Date adopted
 - Link to module specification
 - Declared layer dependencies

C.3 Layer-by-Layer Summary

For each layer (0–6):

- Implemented artifacts (with links)
- Deviations or adaptations (with links)
- Known challenges and failure modes encountered

Recommended format:

Layer	Required artifacts implemented	Public link(s)	Version/date	Notes
0	Purpose Charter; Scope Declaration; Invariants Register	[placeholder]	v0.3 / 2026-01-01	Purpose stable; invariants reviewed quarterly
1	Membership Agreement; Onboarding Protocol; Exit & Separation Protocol; Membership State Registry	[placeholder]	v1.1 / 2026-02-15	Trial period is 3 months
2	Decision Matrix; Governance Protocol; Authority Registry	[placeholder]	v0.8 / 2026-03-10	Consent for ops, vote for strategic
3	Internal Economy Protocol; Treasury Ruleset	[placeholder]	v0.5 / 2026-03-20	Monthly treasury reports published
4	Conflict Resolution Ladder; Accountability Protocol	[placeholder]	v0.6 / 2026-04-01	Anti-retaliation policy included
5	Operations Manual; Role Registry; Meeting Templates	[placeholder]	v0.4 / 2026-04-15	Meeting load capped at 4h/week
6	Change Protocol; Version History; Learning Log	[placeholder]	v0.2 / 2026-05-01	Experiments expire unless renewed

C.4 Governance and Evolution

- Decision mechanisms in use (with Decision Matrix excerpt or link)
- Change and experiment history (with links to change records)
- Major learnings and failures (with links to Learning Log entries)

- Deviations register (recommended):

Item	Layer(s)	Type	Status	Start	Review/End	Link
Rotating facilitation trial	5	Experiment	Active	2026-06-01	2026-08-01	[placeholder]
Treasury transparency exception (safety)	3/4	Permanent	Active	2026-04-10	Annual review	[placeholder]

C.5 Compliance Statement

- Current compliance status: Compliant / Non-compliant / Unknown
- Date of last self-audit or external audit
- Audit method (self-audit vs external)
- Known non-compliance periods (if any) and remediation summary
- Evidence links (recommended):

Evidence	Date	Link
Layer-by-layer checklist result	2026-07-01	[placeholder]
Audit notes / findings	2026-07-01	[placeholder]
Remediation log	2026-07-15	[placeholder]

- Known non-compliance periods (if any)

C.6 Public Transparency

- Public artifact index (recommended):

Artifact	Layer	Public link	Version/date	Notes
Purpose Charter	0	[placeholder]	2026-01-01	
Decision Matrix	2	[placeholder]	2026-03-10	

Artifact	Layer	Public link	Version/date	Notes
Treasury reports	3	[placeholder]	2026-06-30	monthly
Learning Log	6	[placeholder]	2026-06-15	redactions noted

- Contact or inquiry channel
- Explicit statement of what is private vs public, and why
- Link to current RCOS-Core version used and change log
- Contact or inquiry channel

Informative Note

Reference Implementations are learning instruments, not endorsements.

